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Urban Segregation

Warm-up:

When you hear the word “ghetto” what do you think of?

Activity:

Examine the [pictures of Charlotte Street](#) in the Bronx (a few blocks from our school). These pictures were taken across a span of almost a hundred years.

Can you put them in chronological order?

1920s	1950s	1970s	1980s	2000s

What questions do these images raise?

Mini-Lesson:

Vocab	Definition	Paraphrase
Urban Decay	Urban decay (also known as urban rot , urban death and urban blight) is the process by which a previously functioning city, or part of a city, falls into disrepair and decrepitude. It may feature population decline, abandoned buildings or infrastructure, high local unemployment, increased poverty, fragmented families, low overall living standards or quality of life, political disenfranchisement, crime, elevated levels of pollution, and a desolate cityscape.	

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Text:

The Creation of the American “Ghetto”

Adapted from “The Color of Law” by Richard Rothstein

Introduction:

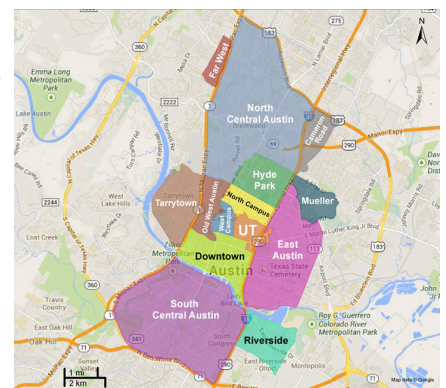
The term “ghetto” originated in Europe, where the majority Christian populations would force the Jewish minority to live within a confined space. They were literally the designated areas where Jews were *allowed* to live. The racial segregation we see across American cities today has much in common with the Jewish ghettos of Europe. Through federal, state and local policies people of color, specifically Black folks, were forced to live in crowded, dilapidated and increasingly industrialized sections of the city - far removed from white spaces. The government used a variety of tactics to introduce and perpetuate racial housing segregation, the effects of which continue to define the American city today.

Case Study: Austin, TX



In 1928, Austin Texas adopted a master plan that proposed a single African American neighborhood on the Eastside. But explicit housing segregation had been deemed unconstitutional by the United States Supreme Court years earlier. Cities could create whites-only schools, stores and parks, but could not create white-only neighborhoods. In other words, the city government could not make a law forcing Black families to move. So instead, Austin’s plan proposed creating an “incentive” to draw the negro population to this [Eastside] area.” The incentive was to relocate segregated schools and other public services for African Americans to Austin’s Eastside, the government designated “Black neighborhood.” Austin city planners had recently developed a proposal to shift African Americans, who were scattered throughout the city to a single East side ghetto. Rosewood courts, Austin's Eastside blacks-only housing projects, was built on land obtained by condemning Emancipation Park, the site of an annual Juneteenth festival. The park had been privately owned by a local neighborhood association. It was a space that the surrounding residents used often and loved- it served as the heart of the community. Residents protested the condemnation of their beloved space. But their objections had no effect, despite the availability of other vacant land.

The actions were effective and soon almost all African Americans in Austin had moved to the Eastside. For example in 1930, the integrated neighborhood of Wheatsville had an African American population of about 16 percent. In 1932, the Wheatsville school for Black pupils was shut down, and by 1950 Wheatsville’s African American population was 1 percent. The city closed all schools and parks for Black folks outside of East Austin, while constructing a new African American library, park and highschool on the Eastside. Additionally, the city built an all-black public housing project far from Austin’s commercial downtown area. In just a few short years, nearly all of Austin’s African American



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residents had relocated to the Eastside, ensuring that Black families were tucked away, far from white spaces.

Once African Americans had been pushed into the Eastside, municipal services in the neighborhood declined. Streets for example, were more likely to be unpaved than in other parts of the city; sewers were poorly maintained and often clogged; and bus routes were suspended during the summer, because those same routes served the University of Texas and were not needed when the white students were on break. And when the city needed new industrial or polluting facilities, such as a garbage incinerator, a power plant or a fuel storage site, those facilities were located in East Austin.

Stop & Jot

A case study is an examination of a particular example in order to understand larger patterns or trends. How might the case study of Austin, TX help us better understand our own city?

This will help us better understand our city because it connects to Robert Moses

This shows the tactics that the government can use to create a “racial ghetto”

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Tactics for Creating Segregated Communities

Cities across America used a wide variety of tactics¹ to create segregated² ghettos. Eastside in Austin, TX, Compton in LA, Chicago's South Side and The South Bronx in NYC are just a few examples. From the demolition³ of Black and Brown housing to the denial⁴ of standard mortgages⁵, people of color were barred⁶ from living in white neighborhoods and essentially trapped in small over-crowded, increasingly industrialized enclaves⁷.

Urban Renewal:

Urban renewal is when a city decides to demolish old or dilapidated⁸ buildings to make way for newer development. Urban renewal often targets slums, housing that is deteriorating⁹. This housing however is usually inhabited¹⁰ by folks struggling with poverty, and in American cities, often people of color. One way cities would remove their Black and Brown populations is through urban renewal policies. Local governments would demolish slums, promising new improved housing for the poor that would never materialize or be located in the increasingly crowded Black districts. As the the author James Baldwin once famously said "urban renewal... means Negro removal."

Zoning Regulation:

Zoning is how a town or city decides what is going to be built where. Throughout the 20th century local governments used zoning regulations to develop their cities, deciding where single-family homes, multi-family homes (apartment buildings) and commercial properties could be built. When a city had designated¹¹ a certain area as a white neighborhood, zoning boards would not permit multi-family units to be built in or near the white neighborhoods, believing that apartment buildings would attract non-white residents. Likewise, Multi-family units were also usually far removed from city's downtown areas where whites worked and shopped. And while industrial facilities, warehouses, truck depot's etc. were not permitted near white homes, zoning regulations were often changed to permit them in African-American residential districts.

¹ Tactics: strategy or action that is carefully planned

² Segregated: separated spaces based on race

³ Demolition: tearing down or destroying

⁴ Denial: to refuse or say no

⁵ Mortgage: a loan from a bank to buy a home

⁶ Barred: prevented

⁷ Enclaves: separate place/space

⁸ Dilapidated: Old and/or falling apart

⁹ Deteriorating: declining in quality

¹⁰ Inhabited: Lived in

¹¹ Designated: Set aside or specify a certain area

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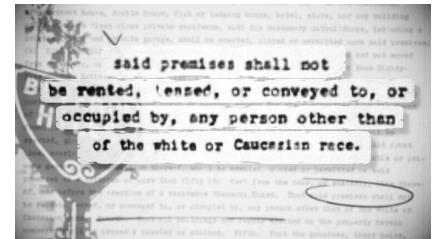
Stop & Jot

Dissect the quote: “urban renewal... means Negro removal.” What is urban renewal? And why would someone say it means “negro removal”?

What is the purpose of zoning regulations?

Deed Restrictions:

Although zoning regulations worked to prevent affordable¹² apartments from being built in the white neighborhoods, they did not stop middle-class black families from purchasing those single-family homes. Deed¹³ restrictions were one way for developers to ensure that single-family homes would be sold to whites only. When a developer was creating a new suburban community, each house built would have a clause in the deed that the house may never be sold to an African-American. Thus ensuring homeownership in that neighborhood would remain whites only. This practice was made illegal in 1968, although its legacy lives on today.



Red-lining:

When a bank decides whether or not to give someone a loan, they look to the federal government to determine whether the loan would be a safe bet or not. In other words, will the borrower pay back the loan? Will the property appreciate¹⁴ (gain) in value? Throughout much of the 1900s, the federal government used race to determine which areas were “safe” investments



¹² Affordable: reasonably priced for people in the neighborhood

¹³ Deed: The document that proves home ownership

¹⁴ Appreciate: go up in value

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and which were too risky for mortgage loans. Green areas were white spaces, which were considered the “best” and loans were approved to properties in these neighborhoods. Blue was assigned for “still desirable”¹⁵, and yellow was “definitely declining.” The areas outlined in red were deemed “hazardous”¹⁶ and no mortgages were approved for these areas. The redlined areas were almost always communities of color. Therefore, no one living in a Black or Brown area would be approved for a mortgage.

Contract Loans:

When someone takes out a mortgage today, the loan is set up so that with each month’s payment, a portion goes to paying the interest of the loan, and another portion goes into the equity of the home. Equity being how much of the home you own. Little by little each month, the home owner gains a little more equity in their own property. So if the homeowner was to sell before their mortgage was completely paid off, they will still have gained equity and will walk away with that cash.

This type of mortgage however, was systematically denied to property in red-lined neighborhoods. Meaning conventional¹⁷ mortgages were not available to African Americans. So instead, Black and Brown folks had to enter what’s called a **contract** loan, in which the borrower does not own any portion of their home until the loan is paid off in full. These loans had much higher interest rates, often in the hopes that the borrower would miss a payment. As soon as one payment was missed, the bank could repossess the house, regardless of how many years the payments had been made. If you had a contract loan, you lost everything if you were to sell your home before the loan was completely paid off. Thus, many Black and Brown homeowners were trapped; If they went to sell before the loan paid off, they would lose everything they had been investing in. White’s with conventional mortgages, on the other hand, could easily sell their home when a community declined.



Stop & Jot

How were mortgage loans used to segregate cities?

¹⁵

¹⁶ Hazardous: Unsafe

¹⁷ Conventional: Standard

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Discussion Questions:

a. Is “ghetto” an appropriate word to use to describe our community?

b. How might these segregation tactics be connected to urban decay?

c. How might these manufactured “ghettos” have impacted the dominant narrative about people of color?